negotiate the appeals process to overturn his convictions. The retirement in September of the previous Chief Justice of Pakistan, Umar Ata Bandial, who was considered by many as decidedly pro-Imran Khan, might have made things easier for Sharif, but there are still plenty of judges around in the higher courts who could yet throw a spanner in his plans to resurrect his political career.

To be fair, the Supreme Court judgment disqualifying Nawaz Sharif as prime minister in 2017 has been widely criticised by legal experts as being inherently flawed. However, in a blow to Sharif, the new Supreme Court recently struck down—by the narrowest of margins, 8 to 7—the right of appeal against old suo motu judgments such as the one against the PML-N supremo. For its part, the previous parliament changed the law so that disqualification for life was amended to a span of five years—a time period Sharif has already crossed—but this, too, could be challenged in the courts in future.

The corruption conviction against Sharif in the Al-Azizia Steel Mills case is also controversial. The judge who handed

PML-N is presenting Nawaz Sharif as the saviour, the out-of-the-box solution for Pakistan's current economic crises

Sharif a seven-year sentence in December 2018—which he was serving when he fell ill in 2019 and was permitted to leave the country—was later caught on tape admitting he had been under pressure to do so. After his return to Pakistan on October 21, Sharif filed petitions to revive appeals against his conviction in both the Al-Aziza and the Avenfield Apartments case. In the latter, he was given a 10-year sentence in July 2018, but which was set aside three months later by the Islamabad High Court pending appeal.

Secondly, Nawaz Sharif must deal with resentments within his own party that is currently negotiating its first generational shift. Sharif's choice for a successor is his daughter Maryam,



THE THIRD MAN
Pakistan's Chief of Army Staff Gen. Asim Munir

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